

medical care, and harsh punishments for misbehavior. An estimated 165,000 people died in the camps—from starvation, disease, exhaustion, suicide, and by execution.

Bribery and extortion payments by family members inside and outside of Vietnam allowed some of the incarcerated to survive and even buy release. Commenting on their propaganda efforts to hide the horrors of the camps, an SRV official joked that “We’ve been worse than Pol Pot, but the outside world knows nothing.”



Paying the price

Prisoners do manual labor in a re-education camp. The camps engaged in indoctrination but, despite the name, were more about punishment than converting people to communism.

Singled out

Religious people, especially Christians, were persecuted, as were ethnic minorities, including the significant Chinese population. Among the major targets were approximately 30 tribes of Montagnards (today called Degars), who had cooperated with the French and later the US in the two Indochina wars. Fighting for their cultures and autonomy, many Montagnards continued to resist for both ethnic and religious reasons. The new regime responded harshly, slaughtering thousands of tribespeople.

Economic adaptation